



IN SEARCH OF A LOST CAUSE

In a desperate attempt to come out of his political exile, Raj Thackeray courts controversy by playing the "Maratha pride" card and creates a sectarian divide in India's economic powerhouse

■ By Adit Pai

Imitation, they say, is the best form of flattery, but when political orphans like Raj Thackeray blindly duplicate archaic agendas of old leaders like Shiv Sena supremo Bal Thackeray, the result can only be disastrous. Two years after he quit the party to launch an "inclusive and wider secular" party, the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS), Raj is still in search of an agenda. In the two years since the fallout with his famous uncle, he has failed to make any impact on the state's politics and has been wallowing in political anonymity. To bounce back to the front pages, he recently chose a novel though crude way—bashing immigrants from the north, particularly



"Why is Amitabh ambassador of UP? Why does Lalu Prasad give all the jobs in Indian Railways to fellow Biharis?"

RAJ THACKERAY MNS CHIEF

Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, and targeting Amitabh Bachchan, easily Mumbai's most high-profile import.

There was little doubt that it was a last-ditch attempt to save his flagging political career. He ridiculed Bachchan for being the "brand ambassador of Uttar Pradesh" instead of Maharashtra and for establishing a school there while he lived in Mumbai. In doing so, he chose to position himself as the champion of Maratha pride. Then began a slew of attacks on the Samajwadi Party (SP)—essentially an outfit that belongs to Uttar Pradesh but with limited appeal in Mumbai—and on Biharis with stuff like "festivals like the Chhat Puja (of religious significance to Biharis) have no place in the city".

A rally of the United National